

DRUG USERS AND GUN RIGHTS

Justices will weigh whether ‘habitual’ lawbreakers should be able to keep firearms.

By David G. Savage

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court agreed Monday to decide if “habitual drug users” should lose their gun rights under the 2nd Amendment.

The Trump administration is defending a federal gun control law dating to 1968 and challenging the rulings of two conservative appeals courts that struck down the ban on gun possession by any “unlawful user” of illegal drugs, including marijuana.

President Trump’s solicitor general, D. John Sauer, described the right to keep and bear arms as “fundamental ... and essential to ordered liberty.” If this right were restricted unduly, he told the court, it would “present a grave threat to Americans’ most cherished freedoms.”

But there are “narrow circumstances” that call for limiting gun rights, he said. Well-armed drug addicts “present unique dangers to society — especially because they pose a grave risk of armed, hostile encounters with police officers while impaired,” he said.

UCLA law professor Adam Winkler said the administration’s stand is not entirely surprising. “Gun cases sometimes pose a dilemma for law-and-order conservatives,” he said.

He noted that last year, the Supreme Court rejected a 2nd Amendment claim from a Texas man who was charged with domestic violence.

In most instances, he said, conservatives would be inclined to support punishments for drug abusers. However, both gun rights supporters and critics of the drug laws have questioned the harsh criminal penalties for mere gun possession. They point out that tens of millions of Americans are both marijuana users and gun owners.

A defense lawyer for the Texas man whose case will be heard argued it was especially unfair for a gun owner to face a potential long prison term for using marijuana that is legal in many states.

“Millions of Americans are currently violating” the federal law, said attorney Zachary Newland of Evergreen, Colo. If they possess a firearm, they could be charged and sentenced to up to 15 years in prison, he added.

[See Guns, A7]



MARIO TAMA Getty Images

MILITARY helicopters fly Saturday as Vice President JD Vance arrives for the Marine Corps’ 250th birthday event at Camp Pendleton in San Diego County.



California Highway Patrol, satellite image by Google Earth

LORENA ELEBEE Los Angeles Times

How military’s live fire over I-5 went awry

Shrapnel falling on freeway at Camp Pendleton confirms state officials’ fears.

By Rong-Gong Lin II, Hannah Fry and Melody Gutierrez

It was supposed to be a boisterous event at Camp Pendleton celebrating 250 years of the U.S. Marine Corps that included a live simulation of a beach assault by sea and air.

The plan involved Marines firing high explosive rounds from M777 howitzers — artillery used to launch shells in wars in Afghanistan and Ukraine — into designated ranges. Federal officials last week insisted it would be done with “all safety precautions in place” and said no public highways would be closed.

But California officials last week expressed fears about those live rounds being fired over Interstate 5, which runs between the

beach where the “landing” was taking place and the rest of the sprawling military installation.

Then, on Friday evening, the Marines did a test run, firing artillery rounds over I-5, according to the governor’s office — while motorists drove on the freeway. The California Department of Transportation captured the live fire on video.

Early Saturday morning, Gov. Gavin Newsom announced the closure that day of a 17-mile stretch of the interstate — from just south of San Clemente to just north of Oceanside — during the event, which an estimated 15,000 attended and included a speech by Vice President JD Vance.

Now, the California Highway Patrol is reporting that a CHP cruiser parked on an onramp of Interstate 5 was hit by falling shrapnel after an artillery round exploded midair, far earlier than intended, forcing an early end to the artillery demonstration. Although no one was hurt, the revelations [See Military, A6]

U.S. alliance with Colombia in peril

Trump’s airstrikes and leaders’ verbal attacks harm partnership to fight drug trafficking.

By Kate Linticum and Patrick J. McDonnell

MEXICO CITY — For decades, Colombia and the United States have been devoted allies, sharing military intelligence, a robust trade relationship and a multi-billion-dollar fight against drug trafficking.

Now that is all at risk as the U.S. ramps up deadly



RAUL ARBOLEDA AFP/Getty Images

COLOMBIA has defended its record in deterring drug trafficking despite a rise in coca production.

airstrikes off Colombia’s coast and the leaders of both nations trade scathing verbal attacks.

President Trump called Gustavo Petro, a former guerrilla fighter and Colombia’s first leftist president, an “illegal drug dealer.” Petro called Trump “rude” and accused the U.S. of murder, saying an American strike on an alleged Venezuelan drug boat had killed a Colombian fisherman in Colombian waters.

Petro has decried the massive buildup of U.S. troops, warships and jets in the Caribbean, which, he [See Colombia, A4]

Foreign outbreaks point to bad flu season

By Rong-Gong Lin II

Last year’s flu season was the worst California had seen in years — and state health officials warn this year could potentially be just as bad.

Although forecasting disease isn’t an exact science, there are some troubling signs. The flu has made an early comeback in Asia and quickly swelled to epidemic proportions in Japan and

Taiwan.

And stateside, some experts are sounding the alarm about continued lower uptake of the flu vaccine. There’s also the possibility of a seasonal COVID-19 wave — the likes of which didn’t materialize last winter, but had been common since the pandemic — as well as a simultaneous rise in respiratory syncytial virus, or RSV.

California health officials have previously forecast

that this fall-and-winter respiratory virus season is expected to be similar to last year’s. If that’s the case, flu would again be the dominant virus fueling hospital admissions compared with COVID-19 and RSV. During the winters of 2022-23 and 2023-24, COVID made up the majority of California hospital admissions caused by respiratory viruses.

“Having people get vaccinated is going to be really key for influenza,” said Dr. Peter

Chin-Hong, a UC San Francisco infectious diseases expert.

While flu, COVID and RSV are currently at low levels in California, there are signs that respiratory virus season is starting to gear up as temperatures drop and people spend more time indoors.

Compared with rates recorded in the summer, the Los Angeles County Department of Public Health has [See Flu, A7]

DEI on resume can make job search worse

By Saijel Kishan

After seven rounds of grueling interviews, an offer for a recruiting job seemed within reach for David Daniels IV. Until a reference check that Daniels learned had involved wary discussions of his background in diversity, equity and inclusion. The offer never came.

Having DEI experience on a resume can feel like wearing a scarlet letter in an already difficult job market, said Daniels, who lives in New York and held roles at companies including yoga wear retailer Lululemon Athletica.

“There’s this sense of, if you did DEI, we don’t want to hire you,” he said.

For Daniels and others like him, working in diversity made them hot commodities in corporate America just a few years ago. Now it’s a liability. Conservatives

have lambasted diversity work as exclusionary, while President Trump’s ire against what he has termed “illegal DEI” has spurred a retrenchment in many companies. Fearing lawsuits and the loss of government contracts, businesses quickly pivoted, downsizing or dismantling their diversity groups.

That left DEI professionals who lost their jobs stranded, competing for roles in a tight job market. Among the jobless population in the broader economy, about a quarter have been unemployed for half a year or longer — the highest share since the mid-2010s, excluding the peak years of the pandemic. DEI specialists say they’re getting less interest from recruiters than they did several years ago and fewer interviews from companies. To bolster their chances, professionals have [See DEI, A10]



JAE C. HONG Associated Press

TWO FOR THE SHOW

LeBron James, left, and Luka Doncic will lead the Lakers’ bid for an 18th championship. But as the season begins Tuesday, James is hurt. **SPORTS, D1**

Pushing back on sick-day rules

Kids with mild colds can go to school, but parents aren’t allowing it. **LEARNING, A8**

Amazon’s cloud computing chaos

Hundreds of companies, including Snap and Venmo, are affected by an outage. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Some sunshine. L.A. Basin: 76/59. **B6**



Peanut allergies drop in children

By Lila Seidman

An estimated 40,000 children avoided peanut allergy diagnoses after the guidelines for when to first expose kids to the food allergen changed, according to new research.

The dramatic drop in childhood peanut allergies arrives a decade after a watershed study found that feeding peanut products to babies reduced their chances of developing an allergy by over 80%.

For decades, parents were advised to avoid feeding common allergens, such as peanuts, to infants. In 2015, guidance shifted around peanuts for high-risk kids and expanded two years later.

A study published Monday in the journal Pediatrics found that peanut allergy rates in children under the age of 3 dropped by roughly 43% after the recommendations were expanded in 2017. Rates for all food allergies dropped by about 36%.

“What I was surprised by was the magnitude of the results,” said Dr. David Hill, an attending allergist at the Children’s Hospital of Philadelphia and senior author of the study. Even being able to say that allergy rates plateaued “would be huge news, but the fact that we actually saw a reduction in the onset of new food allergy in kids under 3 is incredible.”

Hill and his colleagues analyzed electronic health records from nearly 50 pediatric practices to track diagnoses of food allergies in about 120,000 children between 0 and 3. Fifteen months marks the peak onset of peanut allergy, according to the study.

Kids were deemed newly allergic if they received a diagnosis code by a provider for a food allergy and were prescribed an EpiPen, Hill said.

The reductions in diagnoses were found even though only about 29% of pediatricians and 65% of allergists reported following the expanded guidance issued in 2017, surveys found.

Confusion and uncertainty about the best way to introduce peanuts early in life led to the lag, according to a commentary that accompanied the study. Early [See Peanuts, A6]